Israeli jets and artillery dropped thousands of tons of ordnance on Gaza, reducing entire neighborhoods to rubble. And still, for more than seven weeks, the war refused to end.

Nir died in a plane crash in 1988. Had he lived to see 2014, though, he might have been satisfied. The summer-long war was, in many ways, also an unnecessary conflict, born of lies and miscalculations by Israel's political establishment, and a conflict without a clear objective. Yet it produced no real dissent. Quite the opposite: the fractiousness that had come to define Israeli society had all but disappeared. The largest anti-war rally, in Tel Aviv on the night of 26 July, drew perhaps 5,000 people. There were no representatives from the Labor Party, the Zionist center-left's main political vehicle. Even Peace Now, ironically, avoided this pro-peace demonstration. It was also the high-water mark. Rallies in Jerusalem, Haifa and other cities over the following weeks attracted at best a few hundred people. Netanyahu's approval ratings soared, and most of the Knesset rallied behind him. The media became a nationalist choir. Squabbles over politics and religion and identity were replaced by near-unanimous support for "the operation", which was backed by more than 90 per cent of Jewish Israelis, according to polls.[24]

Israelis, of course, are hardly the only people to rally around the flag during wartime. But the mood in 2014, with its intolerance for dissent and its occasional violence, was particularly striking. In hindsight, it was a watershed moment. Six months after the ceasefire, I had coffee in the lobby of Jerusalem's Crowne Plaza with Dani Dayan, the settler leader, who was making a brief and unsuccessful turn as a politician. (Dayan is now Israel's consul-general in New York.) He reminisced—almost nostalgically—about the atmosphere during the war. "It reminded me of 1973," he said, reaching back to the war that had threatened Israel's very survival. "I hadn't felt the country come together like that for a long time."

Shadows and lions

After decades of conflict in the Holy Land, it seems almost futile to talk about what started the 2014 war. Israeli officials point to the kidnapping of the three teenagers in June. Perhaps the point of departure came earlier, when Palestinian groups vowed to take revenge after Israeli soldiers killed two unarmed teenagers at a Nakba Day protest on 15 May. Or maybe the